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The data science discovery program: A model for data science consulting in higher education

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As one of the largest data science research incubator initiatives in the country, the University of California, Berkeley's Data Science Discovery Program serves as a case study for a scalable and sustainable model of data science consulting in higher education. This case contributes to the broader literature on data science consulting in higher education by analysing the programme's development, institutional influences; staffing and structural model; and defining features, which may prove instructive to similar programmes at other institutions. The programme is characterised by a unique structure of undergraduate consultations led by graduate student mentorship and governance; a streamlined, multidepartmental model that facilitates scalability and sustainability; and diverse modes for undergraduate consulting—including one-on-one ad-hoc data science consultations, extended data science project development and management, peer mentorship and data science workshop instruction. This case demonstrates that universities may be able to initiate a low-stakes, small-scale data science consulting initiative and then progressively scale up the project in collaboration with multiple departments and organisations across campus.

KEYWORDS
consulting, data science, data science studies, higher education, statistical consulting

1 | INTRODUCTION

The case of the University of California, Berkeley's Data Science Discovery Program (DS Discovery) offers an important contribution to our understanding and practice of data science consulting. Primarily staffed by undergraduate students, DS Discovery offers twofold peer consulting services to the broader UC Berkeley undergraduate community and extended consulting engagement to projects within DS Discovery. DS Discovery is characterised by a unique structure of undergraduate consultations led by graduate student mentorship and governance; a streamlined, multidepartmental model that facilitates scalability and sustainability; and diverse modes for undergraduate consulting—including one-on-one ad-hoc data science consultations, extended data science project development and management, peer mentorship and data science workshop instruction. Significantly, this case demonstrates that universities may be able to initiate a low-stakes, small-scale data science consulting initiative and then progressively scale up the project in collaboration with multiple departments and organisations across campus. To the authors' knowledge, these characteristics have yet to be discussed in the literature and offer valuable contributions to our understanding of data science consulting in higher education broadly, as well as multidepartmental collaborations and the professional development of undergraduate and graduate students.

DS Discovery Consulting (originally called Data Peer Consulting) started as a campus-wide data science consultation but is now part of the DS Discovery Program, one of the largest data science research incubator initiatives in the country. The DS Discovery Consulting simultaneously offers data science consulting services to undergraduate students across campus while also providing extended consulting services to each of the roughly 400 undergraduate students involved with an average of 100 DS Discovery projects each semester.

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The wider DS Discovery Program connects undergraduate and graduate students at UC Berkeley with researchers in academia, government, nonprofit and industry to offer students high public-impact data science research and learning opportunities. These projects range from a single semester to multiyear engagements, and its project partners have included the United Nations, NASA, the American Heart Association, the Bay Area Rapid Transit, Microsoft, IBM and more in 1000 individual projects since 2015. In addition to providing a unique learning experience for students, DS Discovery is a professional development opportunity with potential employers. These aspects of DS Discovery draw parallels with student-led experiential learning programmes in other disciplines (Kaseda et al., 2022; Pomann et al., 2022).

We see the wider contributions from the case of DS Discovery in terms of its structural scalability and sustainability. As an organisation that has organically developed through partnerships between multiple university departments, its structure and practice are deeply collaborative across campus, contributing to a wider umbrella of data science consultation and instruction. Moreover, growing out of a philosophy of peer mentorship, DS Discovery is largely staffed and organised by highly engaged undergraduate students mentored by graduate students, further embodying a culture of peer mentorship and learning. As an alternative to teaching through simulated experience (Lasser et al., 2021; Shilane et al., 2022), the programme teaches through direct experience (Barman et al., 2022). In turn, the programme prioritises undergraduate and graduate student staff's professional development alongside its consulting services. In effect, a sustainable cycle of peer mentorship has been developed where more experienced Discovery Consultants iteratively train a new pool of consultants to take their place when they graduate. Graduate students facilitate this process through the providing governance of the consulting programme while also mentoring the undergraduate Discovery Consultants.

This case is in conversation with previous reflections on how to foster diversity and inclusion in data science (Geiger et al., 2019) and how to do data-intensive research in teams (Geiger et al., 2018; Sholler et al., 2019). DS Discovery has rapidly scaled since its inception in 2015 and constantly reflects on how to promote more inclusive data science both internally and externally. We view its embedded structures of scalability, sustainability and equity as pivotal to its successful growth. Like statistical consulting, DS Discovery's data science consultants face a wide array of research questions from students with varying degrees of experience in data science (Kirk, 1991). Discovery Consultants have a wide range of data science skill sets, including applied math, geospatial information systems, business economics and cognitive science, equipping the team with the relevant context to help develop interdisciplinary, socially responsible and effective data science solutions. Moreover, the diversity of Discovery Consultants extends past their technical expertise, further facilitating mentorship among students with marginalised backgrounds.

We turn now to a brief case description of DS Discovery's development and structure and then close with a discussion of the wider implications of this case.

2 | DEVELOPMENT AND IMPACTS OF INSTITUTIONAL CULTURE

DS Discovery was founded in 2015 as part of the Berkeley Institute for Data Science, an interdisciplinary research hub at the University of California, Berkeley, that supports data science research, training and open-source software development. In 2018, DS Discovery received funding from the Schmidt Futures, a philanthropic initiative, which allowed the programme to continue to scale its programming and hire graduate fellows.

In 2017, the Division of Data Science and the UC Berkeley Library (the Library) established a joint 'Data Peers' programme within the newly remodelled Moffitt Library. Data Peers offered in-person consultations for campus-wide data science consulting needs staffed by upper-level undergraduate students who were initially all volunteers. The Data Peers programme then developed in partnerships with other departments on campus such as the Social Science Data Laboratory (D-Lab) and Research Information Technology (Research IT). These essential partnerships have further developed since 2017 to a point where current Discovery Consultants are often co-located between organisations. For example, a Discovery Consultant might co-consult on data science projects and co-instruct data science workshops with staff at the D-Lab and hold officer hours with Research IT. In 2019, DS Discovery Consulting received funding from the campus Student Technology Fund to scale its staffing of undergraduate consultants.

With the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, the programme pivoted to entirely virtual consultations and instruction. It leveraged its existing partnership with the D-Lab to utilise D-Lab's virtual 'front desk' hosted on Zoom. D-Lab's front desk is structured in a way where undergraduate students staff the 'lobby' of the front desk on Zoom and then direct consultees to breakout rooms to meet with consultants. D-Lab also manages a large staff of graduate student consultants and full-time staff to maintain the 'front desk'.

DS Discovery also launched its Data Science Discovery Symposium during this time, which enables students and projects to prepare poster presentations of their work. The Symposium serves as an opportunity for students to showcase their learning and accomplishments while networking with potential employers, and Discovery Consultants are often asked to consult on the development of these posters and presentations.

In this period, the DS Discovery Program and D-Lab also launched its Graduate Discovery Fellows programme. This programme funds Berkeley graduate students to serve as mentors, consultants, advisors and instructors for DS Discovery. These Graduate Discovery Fellows provide mentorship to the team of undergraduate Discovery Consultants, offer consulting services and advise on programme strategy.

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The merger with the wider DS Discovery Program, collaborations with partner organisations, changes in student support needs, budgetary demands and the impact of COVID-19 all contributed to the unique structure of DS Discovery Consulting which combines undergraduate student consultants with graduate student mentors.

In 2022, the programme began its next scaling period by formally integrating Data Peers Consulting with the Data Science Discovery Program, which has been operating separately but with some shared staff. Through this integration, DS Discovery's projects gained formal, extended technical support from Discovery Consultants. While Discovery Consultants still offer data sciences consultations for any undergraduate, graduate and researcher on Berkeley's campus, they also now offer extended, embedded support to DS Discovery's projects, helping both the students and the research project manager.

The DS Discovery's Consulting Services also embody the organic, collaborative culture rooted in the programme's development. As a service, DS Discovery's consulting aims to develop data science capabilities among undergraduates by solving technical issues while promoting student learning and skills development.

3 | STAFFING AND STRUCTURAL MODEL

The DS Discovery Program is organised between three teams—consulting, outreach and analytics—all staffed by undergraduate students, graduate students and full-time staff. The consulting team has a unique staffing model among these three teams where a team of roughly 10 undergraduate students serve as Discovery Consultants and two graduate students serve as Graduate Discovery Fellows. While the two full-time professional staff are still involved with the consulting team, most of the administration on the consulting side of the programme is handled by the undergraduate 'Team Leads', with the Graduate Discovery Fellows providing mentorship and oversight. Figure 1 illustrates this model.

One of the most innovative aspects of DS Discovery is its unique involvement of undergraduate students as Discovery Consultants. While Discovery Consultants leverage their technical knowledge and data science domain emphasis to assist with various data science projects, they also learn from the exposure to those diverse projects. Unlike established professionals and graduate students, undergraduate Discovery Consultants may be in the process of developing a more refined outline of their future career goals and long-term professional aspirations. As such, this model helps undergraduate staff expand their toolbelt by learning and applying technical skills within and beyond their domain emphasis, thus becoming better equipped to pursue compelling career opportunities. DS Discovery does offer not only external assistance to DS Discovery projects and the broader UC Berkeley undergraduate community but also internal guidance for consultants. One outcome of this model is that the programme has developed a unique sustainability by cultivating a particularly passionate team of consultants who personally benefit from their work.

Growing out of the Data Peers programme, the DS Discovery Consultant teams are intentionally a student-led effort. Until recently, the undergraduate Discovery Consultants self-organised their consulting efforts, where more experienced consultants were appointed as 'Team Leads' who would help manage newer consultants, lead onboarding and orientation and develop and deliver instructional material. As the programme has scaled, some of the Graduate Discovery Fellows have provided more strategic guidance on programme planning outside the advanced consulting work. However, there remains a strong culture of undergraduate initiative and self-organisation. Discovery Consultants self-delegate to complete the tasks with advising from the graduate fellows. When each of the roughly 100 DS Discovery projects needs to be assigned each semester, the Discovery Consultants organise among themselves to select their projects. Additionally, instead of assigning a particular data science workshop to a Discovery Consultant, they develop instructional materials themselves based on their interests, strengths and peer demand.

The consulting team's organic, student-led organisational structure typically begins with an assessment of new consultants' current data science competencies through the hiring and onboarding process. Discovery Consultants are selected for their advanced skill sets, on-the-job training and mentorship experience. From there, every Discovery Consultant develops skills related to project management, problem-solving, customer service,

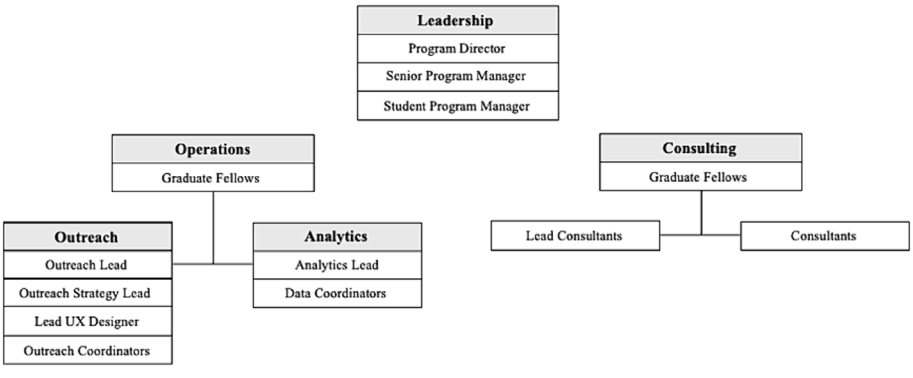


FIGURE 1 DS Discovery organisational structure.

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collaboration, technical expertise and instruction through an instructional onboarding process and close peer mentorship with more experienced Discovery Consultants and Graduate Discovery Fellows. These targeted strategies and on-the-job learning stemming from navigating unforeseen technical challenges through the consultation process constitute a dynamic, active learning environment. As Discovery Consultants gain experience, they gradually develop specialty areas not often taught in their existing coursework. These areas include project management, workshop development and cloud computing. These specialty areas are chosen in combination with Discovery Consultants' interests, professional development and team needs. Each segment is carefully curated to address distinct aspects of data science consulting, allowing Discovery Consultants to deepen their expertise in targeted domains. After gaining experience in their specialised interests, Discovery Consultants are nominated as 'Team Leads' who then lead consultations in their concentration. When new Discovery Consultants join the team, they work closely with Team Leads to develop their expertise in the specific concentration, positioning them to eventually become Team Leads themselves. This self-sustaining leadership model efficiently trains and educates new staff, allows experienced Discovery Consultants to practice onboarding and offboarding teammates and guarantees seamless transitions by positioning new Consultants to fill in Team Lead roles in the future.

The workshop development Team Lead collaborates closely with the D-Lab and the Library to organise and conduct workshops on various data science topics. These workshops cover a spectrum of subjects, including data analysis with Python, text analysis and structured query language (SQL). By engaging with college students in the Bay Area, both in-person and through virtual sessions on platforms like Zoom, Discovery Consultants take on leadership roles, guiding participants through the intricacies of these subjects. This not only enhances Discovery Consultants' teaching and communication skills but also contributes to the data science initiative of making data science education accessible to all by sharing valuable knowledge with the broader community.

The cloud computing Team Lead works closely with Research IT to support students involved with group projects that leverage cloud computing resources such as Azure and the Savio High-Performance Cloud Computing service. Through this collaboration, Discovery Consultants not only gain hands-on experience with cutting-edge technologies but also actively contribute to the successful implementation of data science projects.

Lastly, the project management Team Lead typically takes on projects with more intense management needs, which often entails managing a project directly. Team Leads in this area receive additional mentorship from the Graduate Discovery Fellows related to the management of teams, project partner relations and project planning and execution.

4 | IMPLICATIONS FOR DATA SCIENCE CONSULTING

UC Berkeley's Data Science Discovery Program's development and structure reveal many implications for the broader data science consulting community, its unique structure of undergraduate consultations led by graduate student mentorship and oversight, streamlined, multidepartmental model that has facilitated scalability and sustainability and diversity of modes of undergraduate consulting—including one-on-one ad-hoc data science consultations, extended data science project development and management, peer mentorship and data science workshop instruction that are the most salient.

4.1 | Undergraduate and graduate student-led

DS Discovery's model of peer mentoring is a unique contribution to data science consulting. As an alternative to classroom-based experiential learning or tutoring, the programme offers hands-on, client-facing data science consulting experience for both student researchers and consultants, all of whom are at the undergraduate level. Rather than relying solely on experienced professionals and graduate students, this model of peer mentoring fosters a culture where undergraduate students learn together, reducing some of the barriers of the client-expert relationship. When an undergraduate Discovery Consultant's abilities are exhausted, they turn to the Graduate Discovery Fellows for advice and potentially hand off the consultations with the research partner to them. In addition to assisting with technical questions, these Graduate Discovery Fellows also make strategic decisions on the programme. This model aims at a more sustainable and equitable approach to data science consulting.

This is further seen in its extension through DS Discovery's internal staffing model, which integrates this collaborative, organic culture. Undergraduate consultants and graduate administrators are progressively developed toward greater expertise and responsibility through colearning. They then go on to train the next generation of staff to take their place as they graduate. In turn, this model has become sustainable in the sense that it organically reproduces.

4.2 | Collaborative, multidepartmental model

The programme has iteratively developed since the mid-2010s in collaboration with UC Berkeley's Library, Research IT, D-Lab, the Berkeley Institute for Data Science and the College of Computing, Data Science and Society. The highly collaborative origin deeply influences the culture and

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structure of the programme today, evidenced by its continued collaborative relationships and cross-service with each of these partner entities. The programme's Discovery Consultants and Graduate Discovery Fellows now offer consulting and instructional services across these other departments, creating an umbrella of data science expertise across campus.

This case demonstrates that universities may be able to initiate a low-stakes, small-scale data science consulting initiative and then progressively scale up the project in collaboration with multiple departments and organisations across campus. This cross-campus collaboration may deepen the organisation's legitimacy, facilitate a sustainable staffing and funding model and support larger university-wide goals.

4.3 | Diversity of modes of consultation

Finally, DS Discovery Consulting has a unique model of a diversity of modes of consultation. Undergraduate Discovery Consultants offer as-need data science consulting services to UC Berkeley's entire undergraduate community and extended services to an average of 100 data science projects involving over 400 students. The range of consulting services offered through these different mediums includes technical support with programming languages, methods of data management and analysis, data visualisation, cloud computing and project management that extend to all phases of the data science process. Moreover, Discovery Consultants develop and lead instructional workshops on various topics in data science such as programming languages and approaches to machine learning.

This model asks a lot of its student staff. To compensate, staff are supported through a culture and structure of peer mentorship and iteratively cultivated expertise and responsibility. Consulting questions and administrative issues are shared among the group to reduce potential burdens on any one staff member, and staff slowly deepen their expertise as they become Team Leads and take on more leadership roles. Consequently, the diversity of modes of consultation deepens the staff's expertise and professional competencies.

5 | CONCLUSION

UC Berkeley's Data Science Discovery Program offers a potentially scalable, sustainable and equitable model of data science consulting in higher education by initiating a low-stakes, small-scale data science consulting initiative with undergraduate and graduate students, progressively scaling up the project in collaboration with multiple departments and organisations across campus and delivering a diversity of modes of consulting—including one-on-one ad-hoc data science consultations, extended data science project development and management, peer mentorship and data science workshop instruction. This grassroots, cross-campus collaboration model may deepen the organisation's legitimacy, facilitate a sustainable staffing and funding model and better support larger university-wide goals. This case contributes to the broader literature on data science consulting in higher education by analysing the programme's development, institutional influences; staffing and structural model; and defining features, which may also prove instructive to similar programmes at other institutions.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

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Anthony Suen currently leads the Data Science Discovery Program at UC Berkeley. Anthony was the first staff hired for Berkeley's Data Science Initiative, and he has played a pivotal role in shepherding its growth into the College of Computing, Data Science, and Society. He has spearheaded numerous new initiatives, such as Data Science Modules and Data Scholars Programs, and has been a driving force behind the National Workshop on Data Science Education and the California Alliance for Data Science Education. Anthony holds a master's degree in International Policy from Stanford University and a Masters in Information Management and Systems from UC Berkeley. (Email: anthonysuen@berkeley.edu).

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